

Individual Training – Key Takeaways

Adult Learning Principles in Defence Training — Day 1

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Commander's Question

What is the Army approach to individual training?

The takeaways below are drawn from today's discussion as evidence toward answering this question. They are working conclusions to be tested and refined over the remaining sessions.

Emerging Takeaways

- 1 Individual training exists to produce operational competence and effect.** Course completion and education are means, not ends. The measure of success is whether the individual can perform to standard in their role and on operations.
- 2 Army learning sits on a continuum from directive to self-directed.** At one end, instruction is prescribed and tightly controlled; at the other, learning is driven by the individual through reflection and experience. Neither end is inherently better — the continuum itself is the tool.
- 3 The right point on that continuum is set by risk, complexity, learner experience and the required operational outcome.** There is no single Army method; there is a deliberate choice of approach against these factors.
- 4 High-risk and foundational training demands standardisation and direction.** Experienced learners, leadership development and professional development can carry greater autonomy, reflection and judgement. Getting this calibration wrong in either direction wastes training effort or accepts unnecessary risk.
- 5 Individual training is wider than formal courses.** Workplace experience, coaching, practice, feedback and reflection are part of the system, not adjuncts to it. Any answer to the Commander's question must account for learning that happens in units, not just in schools.
- 6 Learners commit when they understand why the training matters.** Motivation and engagement improve markedly when people can connect the learning to their role and to operational outcomes. Purpose is a training design input, not an afterthought.
- 7 Frameworks are enablers, not the approach.** ADDIE, SAM, 70:20:10, Bloom's Taxonomy and andragogy are tools Army can apply; none of them is the Army approach to individual training. The likely binding constraint is training governance and the speed at which Army can adapt training — not the absence of suitable frameworks.

Emerging Proposition

Army develops individuals progressively toward operational competence, applying the level of direction, experiential learning and learner autonomy appropriate to the risk and complexity of the training, the experience of the learner, and the required operational outcome.

This is an emerging proposition, not a final answer. It provides the foundation to be tested, challenged and refined through the remaining sessions.